NUNO FONTOURA · FREE RESOURCE

WORKSHEET

The Founder Bottleneck Audit

Every decision that runs through you is a tax on your business. Find them, cost them, and cut them in one working week.

Fillable PDF · 5 pages · 5 days + 1 hour

THE PROBLEM

The queue you can't see

You built the business and you know it best, so people ask you, and you answer. That pattern made sense when the team was small. As the business grows, it quietly becomes the constraint.

The constraint isn't your team, and it isn't the market. It's the invisible queue of decisions, approvals and sign-offs waiting for your attention every day. The gap isn't that you are the bottleneck personally: it's that the operating infrastructure hasn't kept pace with the business.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

62.5 h

average working week for the CEOs studied, with 72% of their time in meetings.

Harvard Business Review

36%

of CEO time spent in reactive mode, handling issues as they unfold.

Harvard Business Review

61%

of executives say at least half the time spent on decisions is ineffective.

McKinsey & Company

> **A significant share of that time is decisions and approvals that should never reach your desk.** This audit finds them in three steps: track, question, then write the rule.

HOW TO USE THIS WORKSHEET

1. **Track** every approval that reaches you for five working days (page 2).
2. **Audit** the list with three questions (page 3).
3. **Write a decision rule** for your top three recurring approvals, then act on it this week (pages 4–5).

Type straight into the grey fields on screen and save the file, or print it and write by hand.

STEP 1

Track every approval for five days

Log it as it happens, not from memory at the end of the day. Be honest: the point is to see the pattern.

DAY	WHAT WAS IT?	HOW LONG DID IT WAIT ON YOU?	DID IT NEED TO BE YOU?
Mon			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No
Tue			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No
Wed			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No
Thu			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No
Fri			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No

TOTAL APPROVALS THIS WEEK

TIME SPENT WAITING ON YOU rough estimate

THE PATTERN YOU NOTICE which approvals keep coming back?

THE ONE APPROVAL TO HAND OFF FIRST

STEP 2

The three-question audit

Go through your five-day log with these questions. If you answer yes to any of them, you've found a bottleneck.

1. What got delayed because it waited for you?

Projects or decisions that sat in limbo, not because the team couldn't act, but because they were waiting on you.

2. What did you approve that you didn't need to see?

Invoices under a threshold, supplier responses. If the outcome was the same whether you saw it or not, that's a bottleneck.

3. What do people ask you that they already know the answer to?

The most expensive category: the team doesn't trust its own judgement, usually because it has never been given the framework to use it.

> **THE INSIGHT**
>
> The real issue isn't delegation, it's doctrine. Your team isn't asking because they're unconfident; they don't know what "good" looks like without you in the room. The fix is codifying the judgement you carry in your head.

STEP 3

Write the rule

Take your top three recurring approvals from Step 1 and write a decision rule for each. A rule with no number in it isn't a rule, it's a suggestion.

DECISION RULE #1

RECURRING APPROVAL what keeps landing on your desk?

TRIGGER when does it apply?

THRESHOLD OR CRITERIA

WHO DECIDES WITHOUT YOU

WHAT "GOOD ENOUGH" LOOKS LIKE

DECISION RULE #2

RECURRING APPROVAL what keeps landing on your desk?

TRIGGER when does it apply?

THRESHOLD OR CRITERIA

WHO DECIDES WITHOUT YOU

WHAT "GOOD ENOUGH" LOOKS LIKE

DECISION RULE #3

RECURRING APPROVAL what keeps landing on your desk?

TRIGGER when does it apply?

THRESHOLD OR CRITERIA

WHO DECIDES WITHOUT YOU

WHAT "GOOD ENOUGH" LOOKS LIKE

THIS WEEK

Three actions

- [ ] **Track every approval for five days.** What it was, how long it waited, and whether it needed to be you.
- [ ] **Write a one-page decision rule for your top three approvals.** When to do it, when not to, and what "good enough" looks like.
- [ ] **Set a financial threshold your team can act within without asking.** The number matters less than having one.

OUR THRESHOLD e.g. up to 500 per decision

APPLIES TO

THE CLOSING QUESTION

If you were unavailable for 48 hours, what would grind to a halt?

That list is your audit.

Want to install this properly?

The audit covers one area. The free VOS assessment scores all nine areas of a founder-led agency, so you can see where the next bottleneck is before it costs you.

Take the free VOS assessment **Book a discovery call**

Sources: Harvard Business Review (CEO time use research); McKinsey & Company (decision-making survey). Statistics are cited as reported.

Nuno Fontoura
Founder, NabiaEdge
info@nabiaedge.com · nunofontoura.com